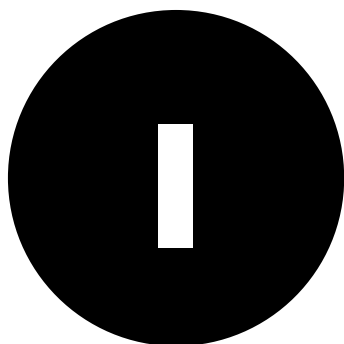




INDIA'S BANKING sector is in the middle of a massive transformation. This time, the trigger is not a crisis, but reforms, led by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI). The central bank's decision to allow UAE's NBD to acquire a controlling stake in RBL Bank, and the entry of Japan's SMBC into YES Bank, are unprecedented in a system that has always kept foreign lenders at an arm's length. Similarly, in the NBFC space, Japan's MUFG is acquiring a stake in Shriram Finance, while Mizuho Financial Group is buying a majority stake in Avendus Capital.

32 | Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman has also made it clear that India needs bigger and globally competitive banks to fund its \$7–10 trillion GDP target over the next decade. So, in the Union Budget 2026-27, she proposed the setting up of a panel to undertake a review of the banking sector for aligning it with India's economic goals. The aim is to not just fund growth but also create banks of international scale. As per the S&P Global, only two banks—SBI (43rd) and HDFC Bank (73rd)—figured in the list of top 100 banks by assets in 2025.

As India's financial system readies for its next phase of growth, the 30th edition of the *BT-KPMG* Survey highlights banks and NBFCs that have combined scale, stability, and execution to perfection. Leading the list is ICICI Bank, the Bank of the Year for the fifth year in a row. HSBC India and L&T Finance have delivered standout performances and taken home two awards each. For the first time in the survey's history, the Lifetime Achievement Award goes to a former regulator, Shaktikanta Das, underscoring the RBI's central role in shaping India's financial system.

ADVANTAGE BANKS

"The broad idea, it seems, is to develop a banking system that has fewer banks which are well capitalised

QUALITATIVE AWARDS JURY

CATEGORY

BANKS

► BANK OF THE YEAR

ICICI Bank

► BEST IN INNOVATION-PSBs

Canara Bank

► BEST IN INNOVATION-FOREIGN BANKS

HSBC India

► BEST IN HUMAN CAPITAL EXCELLENCE

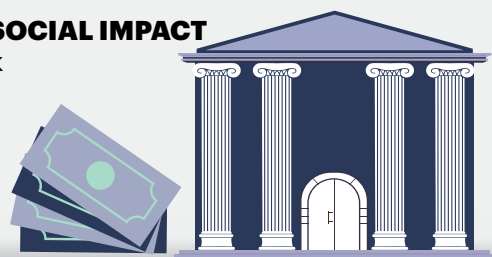
HDFC Bank

► BEST IN EMERGING TECHNOLOGY & AI

DBS Bank India

► BEST IN SOCIAL IMPACT

Indian Bank



and focused and can lend in an efficient and sustainable manner. It appears there is room for international players who have a solid track record and are committed to promoting the long-term India growth story," says Sandeep Bagla, CEO, Trust Mutual Fund. Indian banking is entering a new era where access to capital, experience in lending and international reach will matter more than ownership structure and strategic control, he says.

The RBI has, in the past, ordered caps on the share of Indian promoters in private sector banks, nudging the system towards professionally managed institutions with widely spread shareholding. This has strengthened governance but also constrained promoters' abil-